

From schoolyard mischief to sporting ritual

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When I was in junior school, the last day of the year was given over to the peashooter, and to watching classmates jump after receiving well-aimed shots. Peashooters were sold at stores or could be fashioned out of fountain pens or ink fillers (younger readers may need to ask family elders to explain what these were). Peashooters, however, were confiscated by prefects or teachers. That added another layer of excitement to the activity.

One such round of confiscations by a teacher in a Cambridgeshire school led to the inaugural World Peashooting Championships in 1971. It is held annually at Witcham village in July. The teacher, John Tyson, had a light-bulb moment as he went around collecting these weapons of mass destruction and decided to hold a competition to raise funds for a village hall.

None of my teachers in a school thousands of kilometres away had a similar idea, or the World Championships might have been born in Bengaluru, raising funds and sore throats in equal measure.

The rules are simple. Peas are shot at a 12-inch target smeared with glazed putty from a peashooter less than a foot long. Peas are blown from 12 feet away to hit the centre ring (5 points), middle rings (3) or outer ring (1). The winner in the open category gets the John Tyson Shield.

Recently, one former world champion wrote, perceptively, "The women tend to be very polite to one another, but the men are horrendous. They'll say something rude just as that



Ancient origins: Peashooting dates back to the 18th century, though blowing through bamboo or hollowed wood predates history.

JANE HERBERT

person's about to take a shot."

Like in all sports, there are scandals (plastic peas or ball bearings were used by a team one year) and technological assistance (a laser sight developed by an avionics expert from a US Air Force base, featuring a gyroscopic balancing mechanism, a hyper-accurate laser sight and "bits borrowed from his son's Nintendo").

A recent scandal involved a team which used its own peas rather than those from the bag provided by the organisers. One of the duties of the referee is to ensure that the peas being used are the approved ones and to search competitors for peas smuggled in on their person. Must be exciting.

Peashooting as an activity existed long before the current world champion (Robbie Nicholls, in case you were curious) or the shenanigans in my school. It is traced to the 18th century, although prehistoric man did use bamboo, cane, or hollowed wood to blow through.

In the 19th century, a 'knocker-upper' in Europe was an important professional before the invention of alarm clocks. They were paid to wake people who had jobs to go to. One such knocker-upper, Mary Smith, realised that knocking on doors often woke the neighbours too, and free of cost. That's when she hit upon the idea of using a peashooter aimed at a window to limit the range of the morning alarm.

Such interesting stories, however, must come under the heading *Things we didn't learn at school*. Not even as our peashooters were being confiscated.